

SPANISH VERB CONJUGATIONS - EMPEZAR (TO BEGIN / TO START)

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PRESENT SIMPLE ⚠ Stem Change (e→ie) + Spelling Change:

Yo empiezo - I begin / I start

Tú empiezas - You begin

Él/Ella empieza - He/She begins

Nosotros empezamos - We begin

Vosotros empezáis - You all begin (Spain)

Ellos empiezan - They begin

PAST SIMPLE (Preterite) ⚠ Spelling Change:

Yo empecé - I began / I started

Tú empezaste - You began

Él/Ella empezó - He/She began

Nosotros empezamos - We began

Vosotros empezasteis - You all began (Spain)

Ellos empezaron - They began

FUTURE SIMPLE:

Yo empezaré - I will begin / I will start

Tú empezarás - You will begin

Él/Ella empezará - He/She will begin

Nosotros empezaremos - We will begin

Vosotros empezaréis - You all will begin (Spain)

Ellos empezarán - They will begin

PRESENT CONTINUOUS:

Yo **estoy empezando** - I am beginning / I am starting

Tú estás empezando - You are beginning

Él/Ella **está empezando** - He/She is beginning

Nosotros estamos empezando - We are beginning

Vosotros estáis empezando - You all are beginning (Spain)

Ellos están empezando - They are beginning

PAST CONTINUOUS:

Yo **estaba empezando** - I was beginning / I was starting

Tú **estabas empezando** - **You were beginning**

Él/Ella **estaba empezando** - He/She was beginning

Nosotros estábamos empezando - We were beginning

Vosotros estabais empezando - You all were beginning (Spain)

Ellos estaban empezando - They were beginning

FUTURE CONTINUOUS:

Yo **estaré empezando** - **I will be beginning** / I will be starting

Tú estarás empezando - You will be beginning

Él/Ella **estará empezando** - He/She will be beginning

Nosotros estaremos empezando - We will be beginning

Vosotros estaréis empezando - You all will be beginning (Spain)

Ellos estarán empezando - They will be beginning

PRESENT PERFECT:

Yo **he empezado** - I have begun / I have started

Tú **has empezado** - You have begun

Él/Ella ha empezado - He/She has begun

Nosotros **hemos empezado** - **We have begun**

Vosotros habéis empezado - You all have begun (Spain)

Ellos han empezado - They have begun

PAST PERFECT:

Yo **había empezado** - I had begun / I had started

Tú **habías** empezado - You had begun

Él/Ella había empezado - He/She had begun

Nosotros **habíamos** empezado - We had begun

Vosotros habíais empezado - You all had begun (Spain)

Ellos habían empezado - They had begun

FUTURE PERFECT:

Yo **habré** empezado - I will have begun / I will have started

Tú **habrás** empezado - You will have begun

Él/Ella habrá empezado - He/She will have begun

Nosotros **habremos** empezado - We will have begun

Vosotros habréis empezado - You all will have begun (Spain)

Ellos habrán empezado - They will have begun

CONDITIONAL:

Yo **empezaría** - I would begin / I would start

Tú **empezarías** - You would begin

Él/Ella **empezaría** - He/She would begin

Nosotros **empezaríamos** - We would begin

Vosotros **empezaríais** - You all would begin (Spain)

Ellos **empezarían** - They would begin

COULD BEGIN/START (PODER + INFINITIVE):

Yo **podría empezar** - I could begin / I could start

Tú **podrías empezar** - You could begin

Él/Ella **podría empezar** - He/She could begin

Nosotros **podríamos empezar** - We could begin

Vosotros **podríais empezar** - You all could begin (Spain)

Ellos **podrían empezar** - They could begin

SHOULD BEGIN/START (DEBER + INFINITIVE):

Yo **debería empezar** - I should begin / I should start

Tú **deberías empezar** - You should begin

Él/Ella **debería empezar** - He/She should begin

Nosotros **deberíamos empezar** - We should begin

Vosotros **deberíais empezar** - You all should begin (Spain)

Ellos **deberían empezar** - They should begin

EXAMPLE SENTENCES:

- Podría empezar el proyecto la próxima semana.

(I could start the project next week.)

- Debería empezar a hacer ejercicio para mejorar mi salud.

(I should start exercising to improve my health.)

- Tengo que empezar a estudiar para el examen final. (I have to start studying for the final exam.)

⚠️ ****Important Notes on "Empezar"**:**

◆ ****Double Irregularity: Stem Change + Spelling Change**:**

Empezar has ****two**** key irregularities to watch out for:

| Tense | Irregularity | Example |

|-----|-----|-----|

| ****Present**** | e→ie stem change | *empiezo, empiezas, empieza...* |

| ****Preterite Yo**** | z→c spelling change | *empecé* (NOT ~~empezé~~) |

| ****Present Subjunctive**** | e→ie + z→c before 'e' | *empiece, empieces, empiece, empecemos, empecéis, empiecen* |

! ****Critical Spelling Note**:**

The ****z** changes to ****c**** before the vowel ****e**** to preserve the soft "s/th" sound:

- *Yo empecé.* (Preterite)

- *Que yo empiece.* (Subjunctive)

- But: *Nosotros empezamos.* (No 'e' follows the 'z', so it stays 'z')

◆ **Regular Forms** ✓ :

- Gerund: *empezando* (no stem change for -ar verbs)

- Past Participle: *empezado*

- Future/Conditional: *empezaré, empezaría* (full infinitive stem)

- Imperfect: *empezaba, empezabas, empezaba...*

📖 **Important Usage Note: "Empezar" + "a"**:

When followed by another verb, *empezar* requires the preposition **a**:

| Structure | Meaning | Example |

|-----|-----|-----|

| *empezar **a** + infinitive* | to start **to** do something | *Empiezo **a** entender.* (I'm starting to understand.) |

| *empezar **con** + noun* | to start **with** something | *Empezamos **con** la introducción.* |

| *empezar **por** + noun/infinitive* | to start **by** doing something | *Empieza **por** leer las instrucciones.* |

💡 **Key Tip**: Don't forget the **a** before another verb!

- ✓ *Empiezo **a** trabajar.*

- ✗ ~~Empiezo trabajar.~~

📖 **Empezar vs. Comenzar**:

| Verb | Meaning | Usage |

|-----|-----|-----|

| *Empezar* | to begin/start | Slightly more common in everyday speech |

| *Comenzar* | to begin/start | Slightly more formal, identical conjugation pattern |

- Both are **e→ie stem-changing** verbs.
- Both require **z→c spelling change** before 'e'.
- Both use **a + infinitive**.
- *They are interchangeable in most contexts!*

Common Phrases with "Empezar":

| Phrase | Meaning | Example |

|-----|-----|-----|

| *empezar de cero* | to start from scratch | *Tuve que empezar de cero.* |

| *empezar bien/mal* | to start well/badly | *El año empezó mal.* |

| *empezar la casa por el tejado* | to put the cart before the horse (literal: start the house from the roof) | *No empieces la casa por el tejado.* |

| *empezar a + infinitive* | to start doing something | *Empieza a llover.* (It's starting to rain.)
|

| *sin empezar* | without starting | *Se fue sin empezar.* |

Pro Tip — Expressing "Just Started":

To express that something **just started**, use *acabar de + infinitive* or *empezar justo ahora*:

- *Acabo de empezar.* (I just started.)
- *Estoy empezando ahora mismo.* (I'm starting right now.)

Regional Note:

In some contexts, **iniciar** is used as a more formal synonym:

- **Iniciar sesión** (to log in / start a session)
- **Iniciar el proceso** (to initiate the process)

✅ ****Ready for the next verb!**** Just say: **"Next verb: [verb]"** 🚀